Vijay as a mass action hero.

In fact, *Ghilli* (2004) became a landmark. Fast-paced and packed with crowd-pleasing moments, it expanded Vijay's reach across class and geography, turning him into something of a phenomenon. This phase also revealed one of Vijay's greatest strengths: adaptability. Unlike stars who cultivated a fixed persona, Vijay absorbed what audiences wanted at different moments. He sharpened his dancing, improved his comic timing and developed the 'mass entry' formula that became central to Tamil commercial cinema. At the same time, his fan clubs were becoming increasingly organised, naturally inviting political speculation. Indeed, the main fan club, Vijay Makkal Iyakkam (VMI), with its reported 15 million members, has been critical in the success of the TVK. Party sources say over 60 per cent of the TVK candidates were either VMI members or selected from their recommendations.

A revealing glimpse into Vijay's transitional phase emerged in a 2009 INDIA TODAY Tamil special issue. When asked whether his welfare activities were politically motivated, Vijay resisted the idea, saying "what I do comes from basic humanity", but later went on to admit that "power was necessary beyond a point to keep doing good things". He did not dismiss the idea of entering politics. "Right now, I am fully focused on cinema. I might enter politics in the future."

Over time, Vijay's films increasingly began to contain political commentary. In 2013, *Thalaivaa* faced major release disruptions and political tensions in Tamil Nadu, prompting Vijay to personally meet then CM, the late J. Jayalalithaa, to resolve the crisis. In 2017, *Mersal* triggered a national debate after dialogues criticising the GST system and healthcare policies drew objections from BJP leaders. As demands grew for the scenes to be removed, Vijay put out a public statement thanking the political leaders, journalists and social activists who had "supported freedom of expression".

Though he denied it at the time, in hindsight, moments like the 2021 bicycle ride to vote during fuel price protests, the remarks interpreted as criticism of excessive freebie politics, all seem carefully calibrated to reinforce his political image. In Tamil Nadu, cinema and politics share a long emotional vocabulary. No one since MGR has done better in channelising this dialogue than Vijay.

The noughties also revealed one of Vijay's greatest strengths: adaptability. Unlike stars who cultivated a fixed persona, Vijay absorbed what audiences wanted at different moments, and delivered



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The Whistle Calls

Vijay's campaign was built less on organisational depth than on a carefully cultivated political persona that positioned him as an outsider confronting an entrenched political order. Framing himself as a vehicle for change, his speeches repeatedly returned to corruption, governance failures, unemployment and the concentration of power within dynastic political families. He also relied on direct, emotionally charged communication that drew from his screen persona: sharp dialogue delivery, moral positioning and a carefully crafted image of personal integrity.

The anti-incumbency against the M.K. Stalin regime created fertile ground for that messaging. Throughout the campaign, Vijay repeatedly targeted Stalin, at times referring to him as "uncle", and then backing off to remark that even calling him so itself invited anger. Curiously, while he identified the BJP as his ideological opponent, his criticism of the saffron side was always a little muted.

At the same time, Vijay's campaign also exposed the limits of his transition from star to full-time politician. Critics pointed to the unevenness of his political engagement, especially highlighting his response to the Karur tragedy. Vijay took nearly 60 hours to react publicly, and when he did, the intervention quickly turned into a political attack on Stalin rather than acknowledging the criticism over his delayed arrival and the lack of crowd management.

Vijay also missed several scheduled appearances, and also spoke the least among the three top leaders (the others being Stalin and EPS). Local candidates frequently relied on hologram projections, recorded messages and his celebrity image to sustain campaign momentum. In Kumbakonam, for instance, the TVK candidate R. Vinoth used Vijay's hologram extensively; he still won by a slender margin. It seems none of these limitations diminished Vijay's appeal. The party symbol, the whistle, was loud and clear in the state.

Political observers say the biggest